THE UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG
DEPARTMENT OF COMMON CORE
Cover Sheet for Submitting Assignments

Course code and title:	**CCGL9065 Our Response to Climate Change: Hong Kong 2100**
Course term and year taken:	**Semester 2, Year 1**
Full name:	**SY Martina Bianca Roman**
Student number:	**3036529636**
Class number (if applicable):	**Section 2A**
Type of assignment (eg. Essay, Project report):	**Final Essay**
Word count: *The word count **excludes** contents page, acknowledgments, appendices, the st of references and bibliographies but **includes** the footnotes, glossary, aps, diagrams and all words in any tables. It also **includes** any quotations om other sources.*	**749 words**

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Introduction

That shirt you dropped into an H&M recycling bin is now lying in a landfill in Ghana, alongside 314,000 kilos of discarded clothes. (Daly-Tempelaar) Sustainability has become the latest buzzword that many fashion companies implement in their operations as a façade to real climate action. ("Sustainability in Fashion") The role of Hong Kong consumers is crucial in accelerating and pressuring companies to be accountable to real action. A radical shift in how we value clothing through creating curated wardrobes and rejecting the culture of disposability is necessary to confront this climate crisis.

Corporate Greenwashing

Don't trust the recycling programs of fashion giants. With campaigns like H&M's "Let's Close the Loop" promising to transform old garments into new ones, investigations expose the truth which is clothes shipped to landfills in Ghana and Benin, overwhelming communities already burdened by waste (Daly-Tempelaar). Recycling bins in these stores are not climate solutions but accessories of greenwashing, staged to distract from consumer guilt while continuing unregulated production. An average of 402 tonnes of textiles are dumped into landfills every single day from Hong Kong (Redress). The reality is that recycling cannot keep pace with the sheer volume of fast fashion. The system is designed to overproduce, and no amount of recycling can undo that (Daly-Tempelaar). What appears to be responsibility is a façade that masks exploitation and shifts accountability away from corporations and onto consumers.

The Culture of Disposability

In Hong Kong, four in ten people discard their garments after only wearing it once (Redress). To be an "outfit repeater" has been socially marked unfashionable. This stigma reveals how deeply our generation has normalized disposability and fueled the unsustainable cycle of fast fashion. We live in a culture where buying a new outfit for every event has become the norm (Philips). Social media accelerates this phenomenon, with feeds flooded by new outfits, endless consumption and rapidly expiring trends ("Sustainability in Fashion"). At the same time, ultra-fast fashion companies such as Shein have risen to fast fashion dominance in Hong Kong, releasing thousands of new products with turnover rates of less than a week ("Enigma Shein"). This has impacted individuals to face unprecedented accessibility and social pressure to purchase clothing at an ever-increasing pace, a cycle that comes with significant environmental and social costs.

This culture of disposability carries costs that reach far beyond the social pressures of staying fashionable, extending into human rights abuses and environmental ramifications from Chile to Bangladesh. Each year, fast fashion generates 92 million tonnes of textile waste and consumes 79 trillion liters of water (Niinimäki et al. 195) affecting ecosystems and accelerating climate change. Alongside these environmental ramifications, Chile's Atacama Desert has become a global 'fashion graveyard,' where mountains of discarded clothing pile so vast they

can be seen from outer space (Bartlett). Furthermore, the humanitarian implications are equally devastating, exemplified by the Rana Plaza factory collapse in Bangladesh, which killed over 1,100 workers and exposed the deadly consequences of unsafe, exploitative labor conditions (Canadian Labour Congress). These occurrences demonstrate the relationship between the unsustainable disposability, environmental disruption and humanitarian challenges. With the unreliability of greenwashed recycling programs from fashion giants, responsibility falls on us, as consumers, to recognize our role in driving this cycle and to demand change.

The Fashion Climate Solution Is in Your Closet

The power to confront fashion's climate crisis is stitched into our choices: curating wardrobes with intentionality, valuing clothing beyond fleeting trends, and demanding accountability from companies that profit from overproduction. Curation means selecting versatile, high-quality pieces that reflect identity, reducing the urge for constant consumption. Valuing clothing requires repairing garments when they tear, tailoring them as our bodies change, and embracing longevity as a signature style. (Philips) Extending the life of clothing by nine months reduces environmental footprints by 20–30%, demonstrating the direct impact that small shifts in consumer behavior can have on ecological sustainability (Muthu). Accountability means refusing to support brands that exploit workers or greenwash sustainability which force transparency and pushes fashion houses toward durability, repairability, and true circularity ("Sustainability in Fashion"). By rejecting disposability, fashion reclaims its role as a reflection of identity and responsibility.

Conclusion

Ultimately, fast fashion's sustainability narrative disguises a system of exploitation. The evidence is clear from Chile's Atacama Desert "fashion graveyard" (Bartlett) to Bangladesh's humanitarian devastation (Canadian Labour Congress) that recycling programs cannot alone offset the environmental and social devastation of fast fashion. The power to confront fashion's climate crisis lies with us, as curating wardrobes with intention, repairing and valuing clothing beyond fleeting trends places consumer pressure that compels companies to foster authentic change. Through rejecting disposability and demanding accountability, we transform fashion from a commodity of waste into a force of identity, longevity, and responsibility. The real climate solution is in valuing our closets.

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